THE ULTIMATE HIT SQUAD

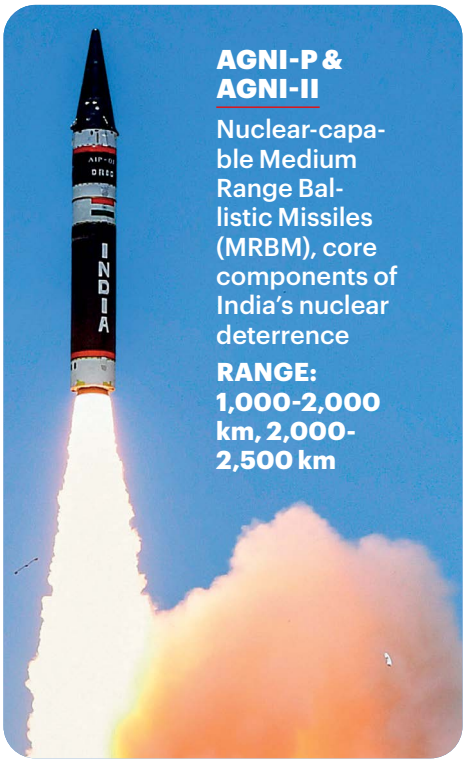
A roll call of the most prominent missiles in the Indian, Pakistani and Chinese arsenals



PINAKA

Indigenous multi-barrel rocket-launcher system; ideal for area saturation fire

RANGE: 40–90 km



AGNI-P & AGNI-II

Nuclear-capable Medium Range Ballistic Missiles (MRBM), core components of India's nuclear deterrence

RANGE: 1,000-2,000 km, 2,000-2,500 km

INDIA

AGNI-III & IV

Intermediate Range Ballistic Missiles (IRBM) for deep regional strike covering whole of China (Agni-IV)

RANGE: 3,000–4,000 km

AGNI-V

Inter-Continental Ballistic Missile (ICBM); with MIRV (Multiple Independently-targetable Reentry Vehicle) capability

RANGE: Over 5,000 km, can reach all of Asia, parts of Europe, Africa

BRAHMOS

Supersonic cruise missile, has air-to-air (BrahMos-A) and naval variants, ideal for high-speed precision strike, used to hit Pakistani airfields during Operation Sindoor

RANGE: 290-500+ km

NIRBHAY

Indigenously developed subsonic cruise missile for deep-penetration strikes

RANGE: 1,000–1,500 km

PRALAY

Indigenous short-range ballistic missile for tactical deep-strike

RANGE: 150–500 km

SCALP EG

French-origin air-launched cruise missile for precision deep strikes, used in Op. Sindoor

RANGE: 250–500 km

prompted this strategic shift," Singh said.

Though military planners are tight-lipped, it is believed that a missile force will integrate the missiles to be used by the army, navy and air force under a single command. A senior MoD official claims, albeit guardedly, that the creation of such a force has strong backing from the topmost security apparatus, including the National Security Council, but has yet to get the final go-ahead.

According to Christopher Clary, associate professor of political science at the University at Albany, there is no universal model for how militaries organise their missile-based strike capabilities. Some countries like Russia and China maintain dedicated missile forces, others integrate assets within their nuclear command structures, while many distribute them among the three services.



"IF WE WANT TO ACHIEVE AN IMPACT, ROCKETS AND MISSILES CAN DELIVER IT. CHINA AND PAKISTAN HAVE MISSILE FORCES. IT'S THE NEED OF THE HOUR"

GEN. UPENDRA DWIVEDI
Outgoing Army Chief

RIVAL ROCKET FORCES

Pakistan prime minister Shehbaz Sharif announced the establishment of the ARFC on August 13, 2025. Earlier, speaking at the Shangri La Dialogue in May, Lt Gen. Nauman Zakaria, the ARFC commander, stated that the newly established force was strictly for conventional deterrence, highlighting the need for rapid reaction times.

Pakistan's nuclear-capable, strategic missile arsenal is managed by Army Strategic Forces Command under the National Strategic Command. The ARFC will focus on conventional rocket/ missile systems like the Abdali, Ghaznavi, Fatah, and the Babur cruise missiles.

Experts say Op. Sindoor exposed holes in Pakistan's strategic deterrence. "Pakistan is plugging the gap they had for long. Its missile inventory does not have many conventional missiles," says Lt Gen. P. Ravi Shankar, former Director General of Artillery.

In contrast, China's PLARF is one of the world's largest missile forces,